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Notes on advances in technology and real-world impact

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Looking Ahead to 2026

As I reflect on the past year and look toward the one ahead, there's no question 2026 will be a pivotal year for AI. Yes, another one. But this moment feels different in a few notable ways.

We have moved past the initial phase of discovery and are entering a phase of widespread diffusion. We are beginning to distinguish between "spectacle" and "substance". We now have a clearer sense of where the tech is headed, but also the harder and more important question of how to shape its impact on the world.

We are still in the opening miles of a marathon. Much remains unpredictable. Amidst this "model overhang," where capability is outpacing our current ability to use it to have real world impact, this is some of what we still need to get right:

1. A new concept that evolves "bicycles for the mind" such that we always think of AI as a scaffolding for human potential vs a substitute. What matters is not the power of any given model, but how people choose to apply it to achieve their goals. We need to get beyond the arguments of slop vs sophistication and develop a new equilibrium in terms of our "theory of the mind" that accounts for humans being

equipped with these new cognitive amplifier tools as we relate to each other. This is the product design question we need to debate and answer.

2. We will evolve from models to systems when it comes to deploying AI for real world impact. We have learned a lot in terms of how to both keep riding the exponentials of model capabilities, while also accounting for their “jagged” edges. We are now entering a phase where we build rich scaffolds that orchestrate multiple models and agents; account for memory and entitlements; enable rich and safe “tools use”. This is the engineering sophistication we must continue to build to get value out of AI in the real world.
3. And lastly, we need to make deliberate choices on how we diffuse this technology in the world as a solution to the challenges of people and planet. For AI to have societal permission it must have real world eval impact. The choices we make about where we apply our scarce energy, compute, and talent resources will matter. This is the socio-technical issue we need to build consensus around.

Ultimately, the most meaningful measure of progress is the outcomes for each of us. It will be a messy process of discovery, like all technology and product development always is. Computing throughout its history has been about empowering people and organizations to achieve more, and AI must follow the same path. If we do that, it can become one of the most profound waves of computing yet. This is what I hope we will collectively push for in '26 and beyond.

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